

LIVE SHOPPING SEARCH INSIGHTS

Live Shopping in the United States

A 2026 Search-Interest Report: the breakout, the platforms, and what is driving the trend

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EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW

US live shopping has moved from a post-pandemic slump to a genuine breakout. After Meta retired its native live-shopping features in 2022-23, category search interest drifted lower and bottomed in mid-2024. It then inflected: average monthly search interest rose roughly 39% in 2025, with a sustained step-up that began in Q4 2024 - around the US TikTok ban drama - and held a structurally higher plateau into 2026. This report builds live-shopping and live-selling search indices from a fresh pull of ~80,000 keywords (Google Ads Keyword Planner, June 2022 - May 2026, US only) and examines the category from many angles: a platform-rotation and share-of-search view, the rise (and fall) of category-native challengers, the collectibles-led vertical story, a lead-lag test showing sellers move first, and an empirical look at trust (“is it legit?”) and how the category’s questions are maturing. A note on method: isolated one-month spikes in individual keywords (a known Keyword-Planner bucketing artefact) are rationalized before any index is summed, so the trends here are not driven by single-month anomalies.

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Executive summary

- **The category broke out in 2025.** Average monthly US search interest across a basket of 196 live-shopping queries rose about **39% in 2025 versus 2024** (from roughly 5,810 to 8,080 indexed monthly searches), after two years of post-Meta decline that bottomed in mid-2024.
- **The breakout is a sustained step-up, not a one-month flash.** Interest inflected in **Q4 2024** and built through **spring 2025** (the smoothed index peaked around May 2025 at ~1.7x the June-2022 baseline), overlapping the US TikTok ban drama. Crucially it did not revert: it settled onto a structurally higher plateau through 2025 and into 2026. (An apparent single-month “January 2025 spike” in an earlier cut turned out to be a data artefact in one keyword; see the box on rationalizing spikes.)
- **Whatnot is the defining company of this cycle.** Brand search for “whatnot” has grown roughly **7x in three years**; it is by far the fastest-growing live-shopping query. Whatnot reported **~\$6B+ GMV in 2025** (with ~\$8B in live GMV cited) and raised **\$225M at an \$11.5B valuation** in October 2025 - double its value at the start of the year.
- **A wave of category-native challengers has arrived.** Search interest is climbing for **Fanatics Live**, **eBay Live**, and **Palmstreet**, while **StockX Live** launches in summer 2026. The hype-driven drops model (NTWRK) is fading.
- **The supply side runs hotter than the demand side.** The **live-selling** index has more than doubled since 2022 (index ~246), and seller-intent queries - “how to sell on Whatnot”, “TikTok Shop seller center”, “whatnot seller fees” - are among the fastest growers. Sellers are a leading indicator.
- **Trust is the gating question.** “Is it legit?” searches scale with adoption. TikTok Shop legitimacy fears spiked after its 2023 US launch and then eased; **“is whatnot legit”** has climbed steadily and now leads, a natural by-product of mainstream growth.
- **Collectibles still lead, but the mix is broadening.** Trading cards / breaks have the deepest, fastest-growing live-shopping vocabulary (+86% over the window, after rationalizing one-month spikes), while Whatnot’s own reporting shows beauty, electronics, jewelry and women’s fashion as its fastest-growing GMV categories.

Twelve things that surprised us

A quick-reference of the less-obvious findings in this report - the things industry insiders may not already know:

1. The much-cited **“January 2025 spike”** was largely a **data artefact** - one keyword (*tiktok live shopping*) jumped a single bucket for one month; rationalizing it dissolves the spike and reveals the real story.
2. The genuine signal is a **sustained Q4-2024 step-up** that held into 2026 - a regime change, not a flashbulb. Distinguish a one-month anomaly from a durable floor.
3. **Live-selling search leads live-shopping search by ~6 months** ($r \approx 0.5$) - a usable leading indicator.
4. **15,000+** QVC/HSN keywords surfaced organically - the “home shopping vs. live shopping” academic distinction has collapsed in practice.
5. QVC/HSN’s **legacy terms decline while “official site”/app terms rise** - the audience is migrating screen-to-screen, not disappearing.
6. **NTWRK collapsed ~96%** from its peak - hype-driven drops are rented; community is owned.
7. **Palmstreet** (live plant/ceramics selling) broke out from near-zero in mid-2024 - the new-entrant pipeline is open.
8. The US wave is **home-grown**: interest in Chinese super-apps (Douyin, Taobao Live) is negligible as *shopping* intent.
9. **“How do I do it”** now outranks **“what is it”** and **“is it legit”** - the market has shifted from awareness to participation.
10. The category is **rotating, not consolidating** - the concentration index rose only mildly.
11. **Brand search is escaping the category vocabulary** - people search “whatnot,” not “whatnot live shopping.”
12. **Trading-card search has the deepest live-shopping vocabulary and grew +86%, but beauty leads the GMV growth** (+791% on Whatnot) - the on-ramp and the money are different verticals.

Introduction and method

Live shopping - real-time, video-led commerce where a host sells to a live audience that can buy, bid, and chat in the moment - has been “about to happen” in the US for years. In China it is mature (an estimated ~60% of e-commerce involves live formats); in the US it has hovered around ~5% of e-commerce. The question for 2026 is whether the US has finally turned the corner. Search behaviour is a useful, unbiased leading signal: it captures demand before it shows up in GMV, and it captures supply-side intent (people learning to sell) before sellers are onboarded.

What we measure

We track **search interest** - how often Americans search Google for live-shopping-related terms - as a proxy for category attention. Two indices are built:

- **Live Shopping index** - consumer-facing queries (e.g. *live shopping*, *tiktok live shopping*, *whatnot live shopping*, *live commerce*).
- **Live Selling index** - seller-oriented queries (e.g. *live selling*, *how to sell on whatnot*, *tiktok live selling*).

How the data is built

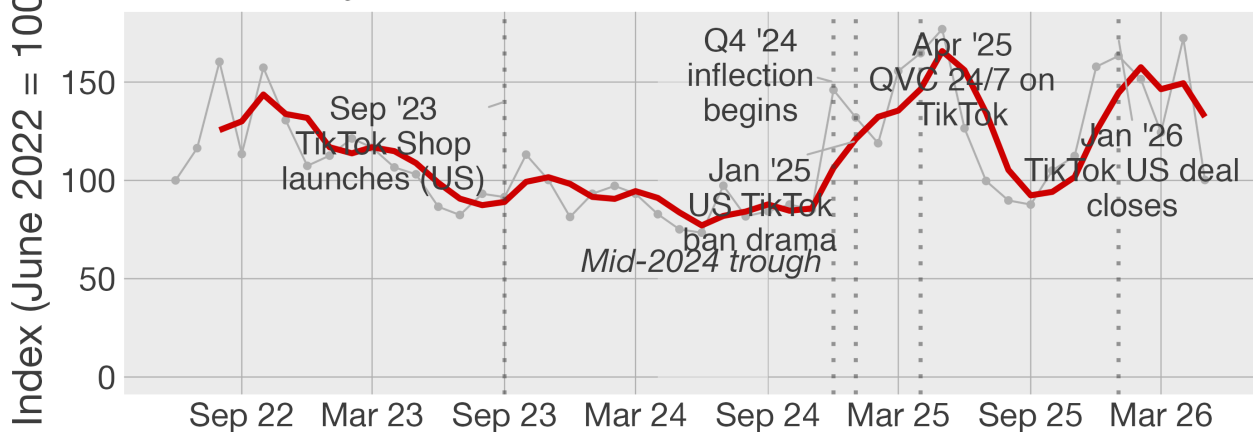
Starting from ~7,700 curated seed terms covering established and emerging live-shopping platforms and verticals, we expanded them via the Google Ads Keyword Planner API into a universe of **~257,000 raw keyword ideas**, de-duplicated to **~79,000 unique keywords** with complete monthly histories. The window is **June 2022 - May 2026 (48 months), US and English only**. Each index sums monthly search volume across its keyword basket and is normalized so the first month = 100. Charts show a 3-month moving average to suppress month-to-month noise; the thin grey line is the raw monthly series.

A note on the data: every number here comes from **one fresh pull** with no spliced-in historical volumes, so the series is internally consistent. Known bot-inflated terms are excluded. This is a US-only report; international markets are out of scope by design.

The headline: a trough, then a breakout

US live shopping search interest: from post-Meta slump to a 2025 breakout

Search-interest index (June 2022 = 100), 3-month moving average. Thin line = monthly values.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 1: US live-shopping search interest, June 2022 - May 2026. The category declined after Meta exited live shopping, bottomed in mid-2024, then broke out - peaking around the January 2025 US TikTok ban drama and holding a higher plateau since.

The shape of Figure 1 is the story of the whole report. Three phases stand out:

1. **Drift and decline (2022 - mid-2024).** Meta's retreat from native live shopping - Facebook live shopping ended in 2022, Instagram's in early 2023 - removed the most visible on-ramp for mainstream US consumers. Interest drifted down and reached its **lowest point in mid-2024**.
2. **The inflection (late 2024 - spring 2025).** Interest turned up in Q4 2024 and built through the first half of 2025, with the smoothed index **peaking around May 2025**. The US TikTok ban saga of January 2025 sits inside this window and clearly added fuel - but the move is a broad, multi-month step-up, not a single-month event spike (an earlier cut showed an outsized January reading that proved to be a one-keyword data artefact; see the box below).
3. **A higher plateau (2025 - 2026).** Crucially, interest did **not** revert to the 2024 trough. It settled onto a visibly higher band, with seasonal peaks (holiday quarters) now towering over the old baseline. Average monthly interest in 2025 was about **39% above 2024**, and the 2026 months so far sit higher still.

The deeper point is the floor, not the ceiling: this reads as a **regime change** rather than a temporary bounce - the baseline has moved up, not just the seasonal peaks.

What drove the inflection

Search interest rarely moves on its own. Overlaying the index against the live-shopping news cycle, a handful of events align with the turns in Figure 1:

When	Event	Effect on search
Aug 2022 / Mar 2023	Meta ends Facebook / Instagram live shopping	Removes a mainstream on-ramp; interest drifts down
Sep 2023	TikTok Shop launches in the US	Re-seeds the category; stabilizes interest
Jan 2025	US TikTok ban drama + brief outage	Added fuel to the Q4-2024 inflection
Feb 2025	Qurate rebrands to QVC Group (“live social shopping company”)	Legacy TV shopping repositions around live
Apr 2025	QVC launches a 24/7 live channel on TikTok	Reinforces the TikTok-as-storefront narrative
Oct 2025	Whatnot raises \$225M at an \$11.5B valuation	Validates the category for investors and press
Jan 2026	TikTok US “USDS” joint venture closes (ban resolved)	Removes the existential overhang for the biggest social storefront

The throughline is **TikTok**. Its 2023 launch re-seeded US live commerce; its 2025 political drama supplied the demand shock; and the January 2026 ownership resolution (ByteDance below 20%, an Oracle / Silver Lake / MGX-led group holding the majority) removed the tail risk that had hung over the single largest social storefront. TikTok Shop’s own scale underlines why this matters: **US GMV grew from ~\$9B in 2024 to ~\$15B in 2025**, and the number of US sellers exploded from ~4,450 in mid-2023 to ~475,000 by mid-2025.

Why we don’t trust single-month spikes

An earlier cut of this index appeared to show a dramatic **single-month spike in January 2025**, which is tempting to read as the TikTok-ban shock made visible. On inspection it was mostly a **measurement artefact**. Google’s Keyword Planner reports monthly volumes in coarse buckets, so a single keyword can jump several buckets for one month and then fully revert. Here, essentially the entire apparent January spike came from **one keyword** - *tiktok live shopping* - reading **390 in December, 6,600 in January, and 260 in February**. A 17x one-month round-trip in a single term is not credible demand; it is the bucketing in action. Because the index is a *sum* across the basket, one such artefact can manufacture a category-wide “event.” So we now **rationalize isolated one-month spikes before summing any index**: a month is capped

only when it is both a sharp local outlier (several times its neighbouring months) *and* large relative to the keyword's own typical level. Genuine sustained rises and recurring seasonal peaks - whose neighbouring months are also elevated - are left untouched, and broad market-wide moves that lift many keywords together survive. The procedure touched roughly 5,000 keywords (about 8,000 month-cells of ~3.8 million) and changed no headline conclusion except to **dissolve the phantom January spike**.

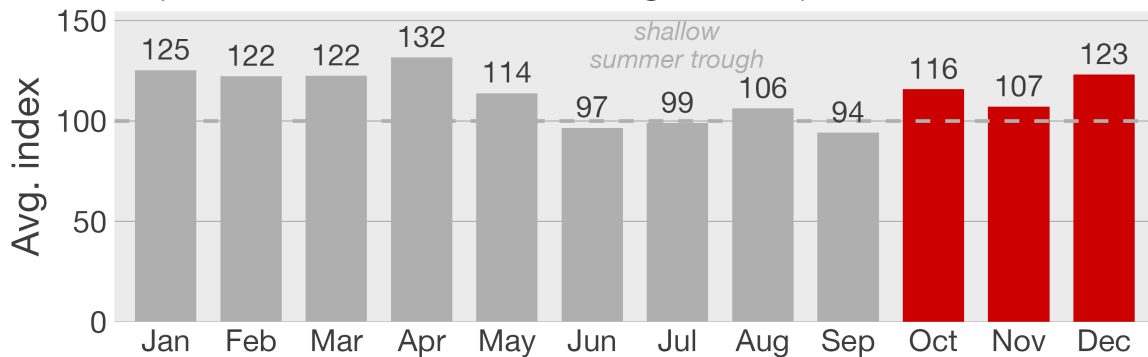
The payoff is a more honest picture (Figure 1): the breakout is a **broad Q4-2024-to-spring-2025 step-up** that holds into 2026, not a one-month flashbulb. The TikTok ban still sits inside that window and plausibly added fuel - but the durable signal is the rising *baseline*, which is exactly what survives once the artefacts are removed. The lesson for reading any summed search index: a spike in one keyword for one month is almost always noise; trust the floor, not the flash.

When live shopping happens: seasonality

Beyond the long-run trend, the category has a distinct **annual rhythm** (Figure 2). Stripping out the level and averaging each calendar month across the window shows interest concentrating in two periods: the **holiday quarter** (October-December, when gifting and deal-hunting peak) and a broad **late-winter/spring** plateau (roughly February-April).

Live shopping has a **holiday-quarter** rhythm

Average search-interest index by calendar month across the window (dashed line = window average of 100).



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

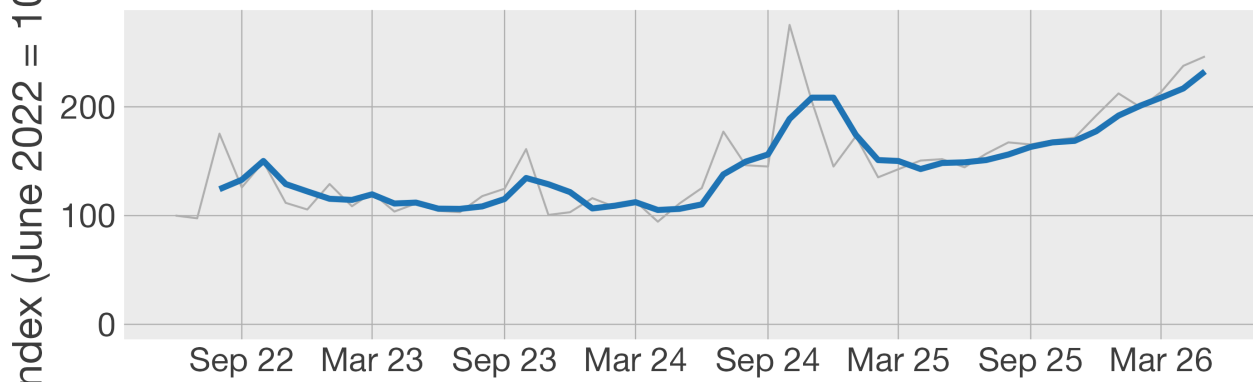
Figure 2: Average search-interest index by calendar month. Live shopping is elevated across the holiday quarter and a late-winter/spring window; the summer dip is shallow.

Two points make this more interesting than a simple “holidays are big” story. First, the profile is **flatter than expected for a gifting category** - April is actually the single highest month and the spring window rivals December, which is consistent with live shopping becoming a year-round habit rather than a purely holiday-driven one. (Once the one-month January-2025 artefact is rationalized away, January is just an ordinary winter month, not a spike.) Second, the summer trough (June-September) is shallow and rising year on year. For sellers and platforms, the practical read is that the calendar still rewards a Q4 push, but the off-season floor is where the structural growth is showing up.

The supply side leads: live selling

The supply side runs hotter: **live selling** interest has more than doubled

Seller-oriented query index (June 2022 = 100), 3-month moving average. Sellers lead the category.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 3: The live-selling (seller-intent) index has more than doubled since 2022, outpacing the consumer-facing live-shopping index.

One of the most reliable patterns in the data is that **sellers move first**. The live-selling index (Figure 3) has more than doubled since 2022 and sits well above the consumer index in relative terms. Seller-intent queries are also disproportionately represented among the fastest-growing terms overall: *how to sell on whatnot*, *tiktok shop seller center*, *tiktok shop affiliate program*, *whatnot seller fees*.

Why this matters: live commerce is a two-sided market, and supply is the constraint. A surge in people learning **how to sell** is a leading indicator that the next wave of inventory, hosts, and content is being created now - which tends to pull consumer interest up behind it. The signal-to-noise on the selling side is also higher: nobody idly searches “whatnot seller fees” - that is someone with a business plan.

A sample of the seller-learning vocabulary makes the point concrete. These are not high-volume head terms; they are the quiet, high-intent queries of people deciding to become live sellers.

Table 1: Sample of seller-intent queries. The full universe contains ~100 distinct “how to sell”-style live-shopping terms.

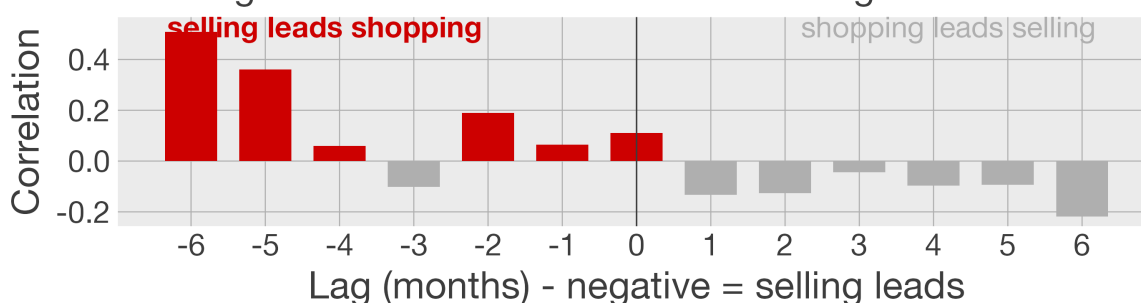
Keyword	Avg.	monthly searches	4-yr trend
tiktok shop seller center		18,100	↑
how to sell on tiktok shop		4,400	↑
how to sell on whatnot		2,900	↑
whatnot seller fees		1,600	↑
how to start a tiktok shop		1,000	→
whatnot seller		880	→
how to start selling on whatnot		260	→

Sellers as a leading indicator - quantified

The claim that “sellers move first” is testable, not just intuitive. If we correlate the month-over-month change in the live-selling index against the live-shopping index at a range of time offsets (Figure 4), the correlation peaks where **selling leads shopping by roughly six months**. In other words, a surge in people learning to sell tends to show up about two quarters *before* the corresponding rise in consumer-side interest.

Sellers move first: **live-selling** search leads live-shopping by about two quarters

Correlation between month-over-month change in the two indices at different lags. Peak correlation sits where selling leads.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

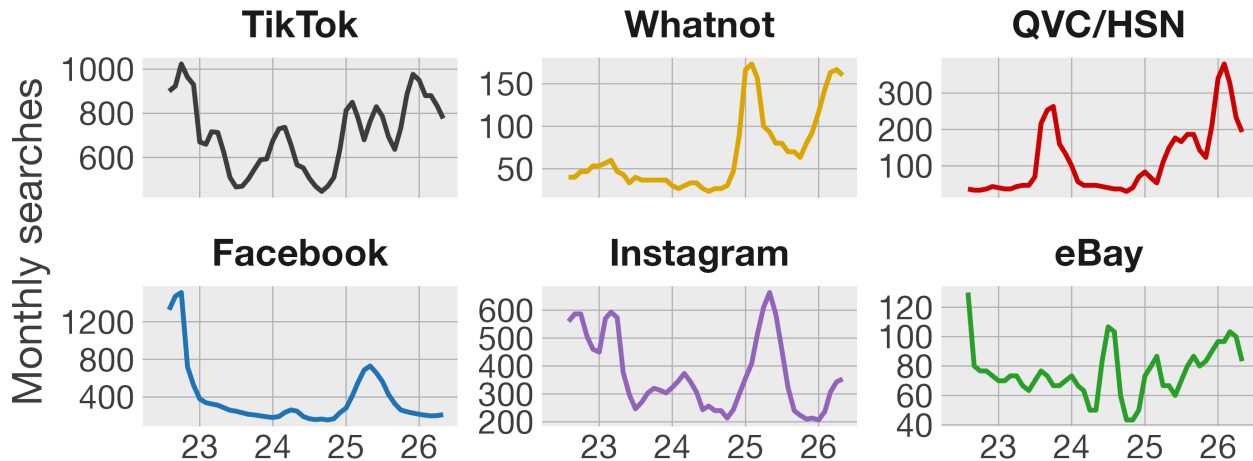
Figure 4: Correlation between the two indices’ month-over-month changes at different lags. The peak on the “selling leads” side means seller interest is an early-warning signal for the category.

The relationship is moderate, not deterministic (the category is noisy and event-driven), but the direction is consistent and intuitive: live commerce is supply-constrained, so the people building the next wave of inventory and content move before the audience does. For anyone trying to time the category - investors, platforms, brands - **the live-selling index is the more useful leading dashboard**, even though it is smaller and quieter than the consumer index.

Platform rotation

Platform rotation in live-shopping search: **Whatnot** and **QVC/HSN** rise as Meta fades

Monthly US search interest in '[platform] live shopping'-type queries, 3-month moving average.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 5: Live-shopping search interest by platform (queries of the form “[platform] live shopping”), 3-month moving average. Whatnot and QVC/HSN trend up; Meta’s surfaces fade; TikTok dominates and spikes with the 2025 news cycle.

When we slice live-shopping queries by the platform named in them (Figure 5), a clear **rotation** appears:

- **TikTok** dominates in absolute terms and shows the January 2025 spike most violently - it is the lightning rod for category attention.
- **Whatnot** and **QVC/HSN** are the two clear up-and-to-the-right trends. QVC/HSN is the more surprising of the two: a 40-year-old TV-shopping incumbent is being **re-discovered through a live-social lens**, helped by its 2025 rebrand and its 24/7 TikTok channel.
- **Facebook and Instagram** fade steadily - the long tail of Meta’s 2022-23 exit.
- **eBay** is volatile but present, buoyed by eBay Live’s expansion into collectibles, watches, and handbags.

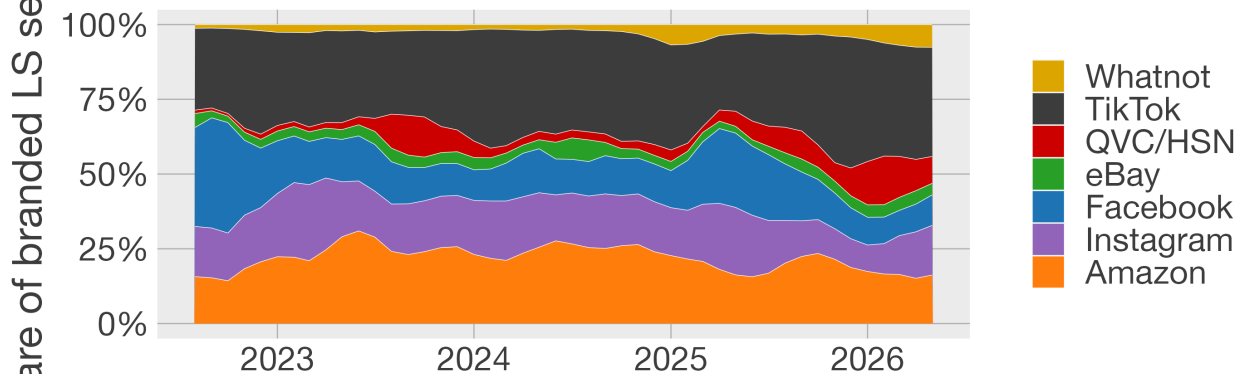
The strategic read: the category is **not** consolidating onto one app. TikTok is the top-of-funnel attention engine, Whatnot is the category-native destination, and QVC/HSN shows that incumbents can re-platform onto live-social rather than be displaced by it - even as the parent company restructures (QVC Group filed a prepackaged Chapter 11 in April 2026 to cut debt while pursuing its live-social “WIN” strategy).

The rotation, in shares

Looking at *shares* rather than levels makes the rotation unmistakable (Figure 6). Among branded “[platform] live shopping” searches, **Whatnot climbed from roughly 1% to ~8%** of the pie, and QVC/HSN gained, while Facebook and Instagram surrendered share they had held since the pandemic.

The rotation, in shares: **Whatnot** and **QVC/HSN** take share as Meta gives it up

Share of branded ‘[platform] live shopping’ search by month (3-mo avg). Whatnot rose from ~1% to ~8%.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

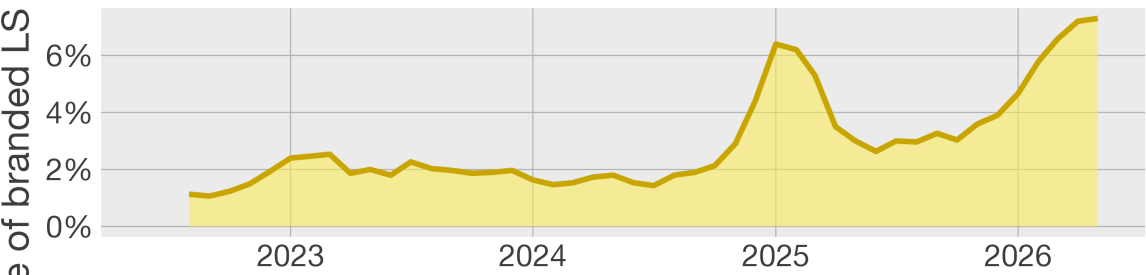
Figure 6: Share of branded ‘[platform] live shopping’ search by month. Whatnot and QVC/HSN gain share; Meta’s surfaces give it up.

Two structural caveats make this more interesting than a simple horse race:

- **The category is mildly concentrating, not consolidating.** A Herfindahl index of branded live-shopping search rose only modestly (from ~1,770 to ~2,040 over the window) - still well below levels that would signal a single winner. The market is **rotating attention between many players**, not collapsing onto one. Figure 7 shows the other side of that coin: Whatnot’s own slice of branded live-shopping search climbed from a rounding error to a meaningful share over the window.
- **The brand energy is escaping the “live shopping” phrasing entirely.** Within explicit “live shopping” queries, the *branded* share actually fell (from ~40% to ~31%) as Meta’s terms collapsed. But that understates the brands, because the real brand search has migrated to *standalone names* - people now simply search “**whatnot**”, not “whatnot live shopping.” When a platform becomes a verb, it leaves the category’s generic vocabulary behind. That migration - from concept search to brand search - is itself a marker of the category maturing.

From a rounding error to a real share:
Whatnot's slice of branded live-shopping

Search
Whatnot's share of all branded '[platform] live shopping' search, 3-month moving average.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 7: Whatnot's share of all branded '[platform] live shopping' search over time (3-mo avg).

Home shopping's quiet reinvention: QVC and HSN

One of the most surprising findings is how **enormous the QVC/HSN footprint is** inside an organically-grown live-shopping keyword set. The seed universe was expanded using Google's own "related terms" suggestions, so the keywords that surface are the ones Google associates with live shopping in practice. On that basis, **more than 15,000** of our keywords relate to QVC or HSN - literally thousands of distinct queries. This matters because the academic literature has long drawn a line between *live shopping* (social, creator-led, interactive) and *home shopping networks* (broadcast TV retail). Google's association data quietly erases that line: in the market's mental model, QVC and HSN **are** live shopping. That is the "academic conclusions vs. market reality" gap in one statistic.

Table 2: A small sample of the 15,000+ QVC/HSN-related queries in the universe.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
qvc	3,350,000	↓
hsn	1,000,000	↓
qvc com official site	201,000	↑
qvc live	40,500	↓
qvc tv live	40,500	↓
hsn official site	9,900	↑
qvc com official site shopping online	12,100	↑
hsn app	2,400	→

The trend split inside Table 2 is the real story. The **legacy brand terms are declining** (*qvc*, *hsn*, *qvc tv live*) - the old TV-shopping habit is fading - while **"official site", "app" and "shopping online" variants are rising**. A 40-year-old audience is migrating from the TV set to the website and the app, exactly as QVC Group's strategy intends.

The corporate moves line up with the search data:

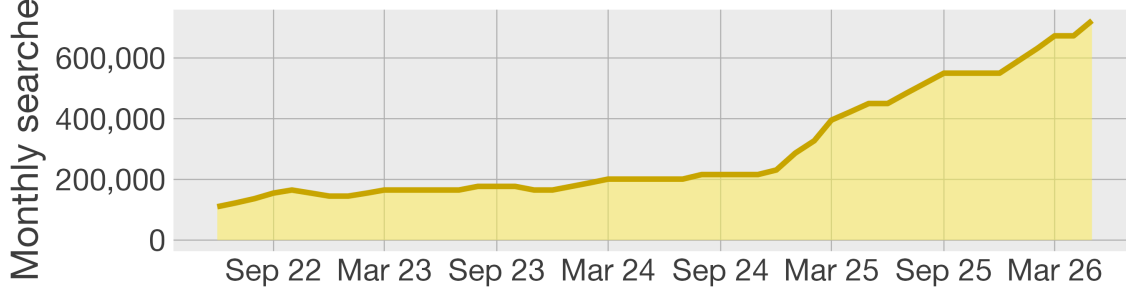
- **Feb 2025:** Qurate Retail rebrands as **QVC Group**, explicitly to become a "live social shopping company."
- **Apr 2025:** QVC launches the first **24/7 live-shopping channel on TikTok** in the US.
- **Apr 2026:** QVC Group files a **prepackaged Chapter 11** to cut debt while pursuing its live-social "WIN" strategy.

The open question is whether a broadcast-era brand can convince a social-era audience. The data says the transition is real and underway; whether it is *enough* - and whether it wins genuinely new audiences rather than just retaining the old one online - is the thing to watch. It is the clearest test in the market of whether incumbents can re-platform onto live-social rather than be displaced by it.

Whatnot: the defining company of the cycle

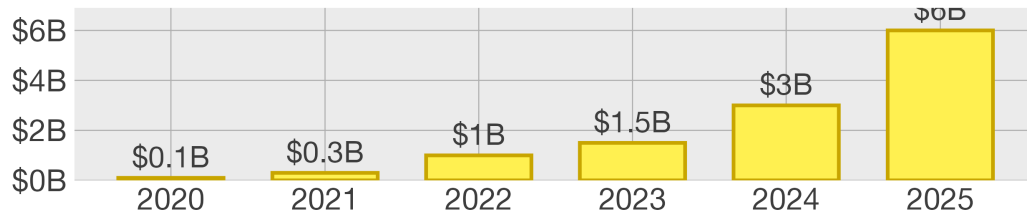
Brand search for Whatnot has grown ~7x in three years

US monthly searches for “whatnot”, 3-month moving average.



Whatnot gross merchandise value (GMV)

Estimated annual GMV from public reporting. 2025 ~ \$6B+ (\$8B live GMV cited); valued at \$11.5B (Oct 2025).



Whatnot GMV are estimates from public announcements. Search: Google Ads Keyword Planner API.

Figure 8: Top: US brand search for “whatnot” has grown roughly 7x since 2022. Bottom: estimated Whatnot GMV, ~\$0.1B (2020) to ~\$6B+ (2025).

If 2025 has a protagonist, it is **Whatnot**. By every angle in the data it is the strongest trend in live shopping:

- **Search:** brand interest is up ~7x in three years (Figure 8, top) and “whatnot” is the single fastest-growing live-shopping query by a wide margin.
- **GMV:** roughly **\$0.1B (2020) -> \$1.5B (2023) -> \$3B (2024) -> \$6B+ (2025)**, with the company citing ~\$8B in live GMV and revenue approaching \$1B. Growth has been close to 2x a year.
- **Capital:** a **\$225M round at an \$11.5B valuation** in October 2025 (DST Global and CapitalG leading; Sequoia, a16z, Greycroft, BOND participating), roughly double the start-of-year mark; ~\$968M raised since 2019.
- **Engagement:** ~80-95 minutes per active user per day, >80% month-over-month retention, and new buyers up ~285% year on year. It ranked the **#1 shopping app in both the US and UK in 2025** and did **\$100M+ in live sales on Black Friday alone**.

The open question for any company growing this fast is whether it can keep doubling. The 2025 data says yes: it both **doubled GMV and re-rated in the private markets**, while broadening from its collectibles roots

into 140+ categories. The risk is no longer demand - it is whether supply (sellers, moderation, fulfillment, trust) can scale with it.

So what is actually driving it? The data cannot fully answer the “why”, but it points at the ingredients worth studying:

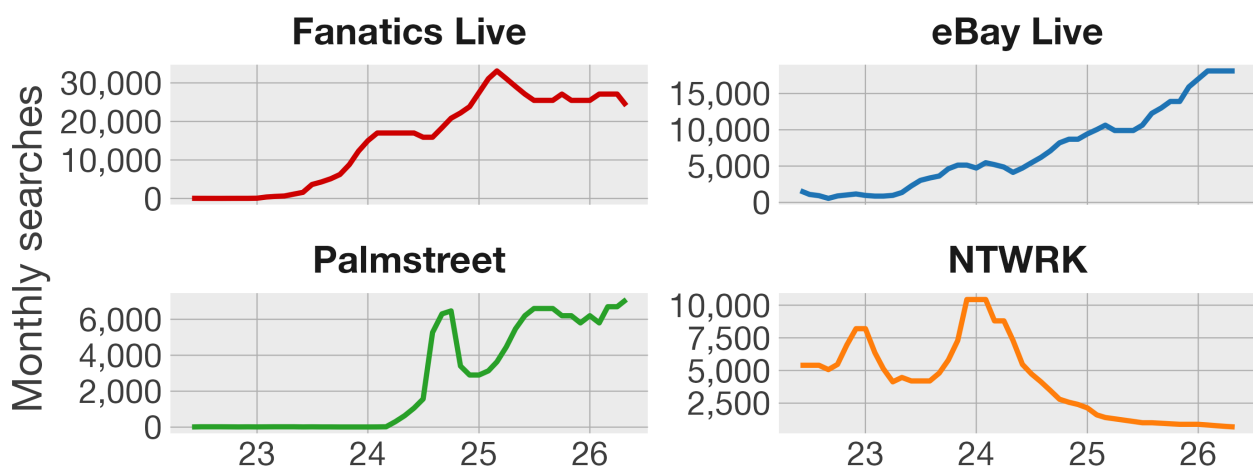
- **Community over catalogue.** Whatnot grew out of a passionate collectibles community (cards, Funko, sneakers) where the live format mirrors how those hobbies already work - drops, breaks, banter, and the thrill of the hunt. Engagement of ~80-95 minutes a day looks more like a social network than a store.
- **Niche-first, then broaden.** It owned a vertical before chasing everything, then used that trust and habit to expand into beauty, fashion and electronics - the categories now scaling fastest by GMV.
- **Format and trust infrastructure.** Native auctions, buyer protection, and seller tooling turn a chaotic livestream into a transactable marketplace. The fact that “*is whatnot legit*” is a top-growing query (see the *Trust* section) is, paradoxically, a sign the format has reached the skeptical mainstream.

The strategic lesson for the rest of the industry: live shopping in the US did not take off as a generic “video + cart” feature bolted onto existing apps - it took off where a real community already wanted to gather and trade.

The challengers

Beyond Whatnot: a wave of **category-native live-shopping challengers**

US monthly search interest, 3-month moving average. Fanatics Live, eBay Live and Palmstreet climb; NTWRK’s drop-hype fades.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 9: Category-native live-shopping challengers. Fanatics Live, eBay Live and Palmstreet are climbing; NTWRK’s drops-driven model is fading.

Whatnot is not alone. A cohort of **category-native** platforms is gaining search traction (Figure 9), each owning a vertical rather than chasing “everything live”:

- **Fanatics Live** - trading cards and sports collectibles, leveraging Fanatics’ licensing and “breaks” culture. The clearest challenger uptrend.
- **eBay Live** - cards and collectibles first, now luxury watches, handbags and fashion; expanding to Germany and Canada in 2026.
- **Palmstreet** - a genuine surprise: a niche live marketplace (plants, ceramics, niche collectibles) breaking out from near zero in 2024 to a durable base.
- **StockX Live** - announced for **summer 2026** (sneakers, apparel, cards, vintage); too new to register in search yet, but one to watch.
- **NTWRK** - the celebrity/drops model has **faded** from its 2023-24 peak, a reminder that hype-driven formats are harder to sustain than community-driven ones.

When they arrived - and who survived

Dating each challenger’s first month of meaningful search adds a time dimension to the story - and a cautionary tale about churn:

Table 3: Emergence and survival of live-shopping challengers.

Platform	First meaningful search	Peak monthly	Latest	Status
Whatnot	Jun 2022 (already rising)	823,000	823,000	At/near peak
eBay Live	May 2023	18,100	18,100	At/near peak
Fanatics Live	Jul 2023	33,100	18,100	Off peak, durable
Palmstreet	Jun 2024	12,100	6,600	Newest breakout
NTWRK	(early)	14,800	590	Collapsed (-96%)
StockX Live	not yet	-	-	Launches summer 2026

The standout in Table 3 is **NTWRK’s collapse - down roughly 96% from its peak**. The celebrity-drops model burned bright in 2023-24 and then faded fast, a sharp contrast with the community-driven platforms that have held or grown. It is the clearest evidence in the data for the report’s recurring thesis: **hype is rented, community is owned**. Palmstreet, emerging only in mid-2024, shows the pipeline of new entrants is still very much open.

The pattern is telling: the winners are **community-and-category-native** (Whatnot, Fanatics, Palmstreet), not generic “live video + cart” tools. Owning a passionate vertical beats owning a feature.

Platform profiles: a field guide

The US live-shopping landscape is best understood not as one market but as a **federation of lanes**. The table below maps the main players by the **role they play in the market** - grouped into discovery funnels, category-native destinations, re-platforming incumbents, and the challenger/toolkit fringe - with their model, lead verticals, and a plain-language read on where each sits in the search data. The **trend** column is the quick takeaway: who is rising, who is steady, and who is fading.

Table 4: The US live-shopping field, grouped by market role. Read the trend column first: TikTok Shop owns discovery, Whatnot leads the destinations, QVC/HSN is re-platforming a huge legacy base, and the challenger fringe is a mix of newcomers and fade-outs.

Role	Platform	Model	Lead vertical(s)	Search trend
Discovery funnel	TikTok Shop	Social feed + live	Beauty, fashion, gadgets	Dominant; moves with news
	YouTube Shopping	Creator + shoppable video	Broad, creator-led	Emerging
	Amazon Live	Influencer streams + catalogue	Broad consumer goods	Steady, low LS-specific
Category-native destination	Whatnot	Live marketplace + auctions	Collectibles, now beauty/fashion	Strongest grower (~7x)
	Fanatics Live	Live + card breaks	Sports cards, collectibles	Rising
	eBay Live	Live auctions	Cards, watches, handbags	Rising; expanding geos
	Palmstreet	Live marketplace	Plants, ceramics, niche	Breakout from ~zero
Re-platforming incumbent	QVC / HSN	Broadcast + streaming + social	Beauty, fashion, home, jewelry	Huge base; re-platforming
Challenger fringe	StockX Live	Live drops + auctions	Sneakers, apparel, cards	Launches summer 2026
	NTWRK	Celebrity drops	Streetwear, sneakers	Faded from 2023-24 peak
	TalkShopLive	Host-driven shoppable shows	Books, celebrity, CPG	Niche, partnership-led
	Popshop (CommentSold)	Live marketplace + SMB tooling	SMB retail, fashion	Consolidating

A few cross-cutting observations:

- **Two super-funnels, many destinations.** TikTok Shop and (to a lesser extent) YouTube and Instagram are where mainstream audiences *discover* live shopping; the category-native marketplaces (Whatnot, Fanatics, eBay Live, Palmstreet) are where committed buyers *transact*. The discovery layer and the destination layer are increasingly distinct businesses.
- **Collectibles is the on-ramp, everything else is the expansion.** Almost every successful destination - Whatnot, Fanatics Live, eBay Live, StockX Live - started in cards/sneakers/ collectibles and is now broad-

ening. The passion vertical builds the daily-active habit; the mass verticals (beauty, fashion, electronics) scale the dollars.

- **Incumbents are re-platforming, not dying.** QVC/HSN's enormous existing audience is being migrated onto streaming, social and a 24/7 TikTok channel. eBay is bolting live onto a marketplace with 30 years of supply. The incumbent advantage is inventory and trust; the challenger advantage is format-native engagement.
- **The toolkit layer is real but quieter.** Behind the destinations sits a B2B enablement layer (CommentSold, Bambuser-style providers, shoppable-video tools). In US *search*, the destination apps dominate - but roughly half of recent live-commerce funding has gone to this infrastructure layer, suggesting investors expect the plumbing to matter as much as the storefronts.

Micro-trends: spotlights from the long tail

The headline indices summarize the category, but the most interesting material is often in the *texture* of the queries - the specific things people type. Below are several themes that surfaced while mining the ~79,000-keyword universe. Some are trending hard, some are flat; all of them are revealing about how Americans actually think about live shopping. (A guiding principle: don't dismiss low monthly volumes - roughly 95% of all search terms get fewer than 10 searches a month, and that long tail is exactly where a trend hides before it is obvious to everyone else.)

What people ask

The question queries are a window into the category's psychology. The "trust" questions now dominate - "*is whatnot legit*", "*is tiktok shop legit*" - capturing a platform going mainstream: as new buyers arrive, they ask whether they can trust it before they commit. (We exclude "*what is a whatnot*" here: at ~22,000 searches a month it is large, but "a whatnot" is also a common piece of furniture - a tiered display stand - so the term is too ambiguous to read as live-shopping intent.)

Table 5: Sample of question queries.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
is whatnot legit	14,800	↑
is tiktok shop legit	5,400	↑
what is qvc	4,400	→
is whatnot app legit	1,300	↑
how does tiktok shop work	1,000	→

Shoppers and sellers compare platforms

Comparison queries are small in volume but disproportionately informative - they show which two options are genuinely in a shopper's consideration set. In live shopping, the comparison that matters is overwhelmingly **Whatnot vs. eBay** - the collectibles incumbent against the live-native challenger.

Table 6: Comparison queries.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
whatnot vs ebay	390	→
ebay vs whatnot	90	→
qvc alternative shopping	10	→

Tools, apps and "how do I go live"

A steady cluster of generic tooling queries - *live shopping platform*, *livestream shopping app* - shows demand from brands and sellers looking for the infrastructure to broadcast, distinct from any single destination app. Whatnot's own app query dwarfs them, a reminder that in the US the destination is winning over the toolkit.

Table 7: Tools / apps / platform queries (245 in the universe).

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
whatnot app	90,500	↑
hsn app	2,400	→
live shopping platform	1,900	↑
livestream shopping app	1,300	→
live stream shopping platform	1,300	→

Trading cards and “breaks”: the collectibles engine, in miniature

The collectibles vocabulary is highly fragmented - hundreds of specific, low-volume terms rather than a few big ones. That fragmentation is itself the signal: this is a deep, active community with its own language (“breaks”, “rips”, specific sets), not a casual audience.

Table 8: Sample of live card-breaking queries.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
whatnot card	480	→
whatnot sports cards	390	→
live sports card breaks	320	→
card breaks live	320	→

Niche breakouts: plants and thrift go live

Two genuinely new niches show up. **Palmstreet** - live selling of plants, ceramics and niche collectibles - has broken out from near zero, and “**live thrifting**” is emerging as a behaviour in its own right. These are the kind of small, weird, fast-growing signals that tend to precede the next mainstream vertical.

Table 9: Sample of niche-format queries.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
palmstreet	6,600	↑
palmstreet app	1,000	↑
live thrifting	210	→

The wave is home-grown, not imported

A useful negative finding: despite China’s mature live-commerce market, **US interest in foreign live-shopping platforms is faint**. The Chinese super-apps that dominate live commerce abroad (Douyin, Kuaishou, Taobao Live, Shopee) appear in US search almost entirely as *app-download* curiosity rather than shopping intent, and genuine cross-border live-shopping terms are tiny.

Table 10: US search for international live-commerce apps - mostly download curiosity, not shopping.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
douyin	90,500	↑
kuaishou	5,400	↑
live shopee	320	→
taobao live shopping	10	→

The implication is strategically important: the US live-shopping breakout is **domestically driven** - by TikTok Shop, Whatnot and the collectibles community - not a spillover from Asian platforms. The American market is building its own version rather than importing one.

Whatnot's long tail

Finally, the depth of Whatnot's brand footprint is itself a signal. Beyond the head term, a long tail of intent-rich queries has formed - fees, selling, the company, the website - the kind of vocabulary that only accretes around a platform people are seriously using and seriously considering selling on.

Table 11: A slice of Whatnot's 125-term brand long tail.

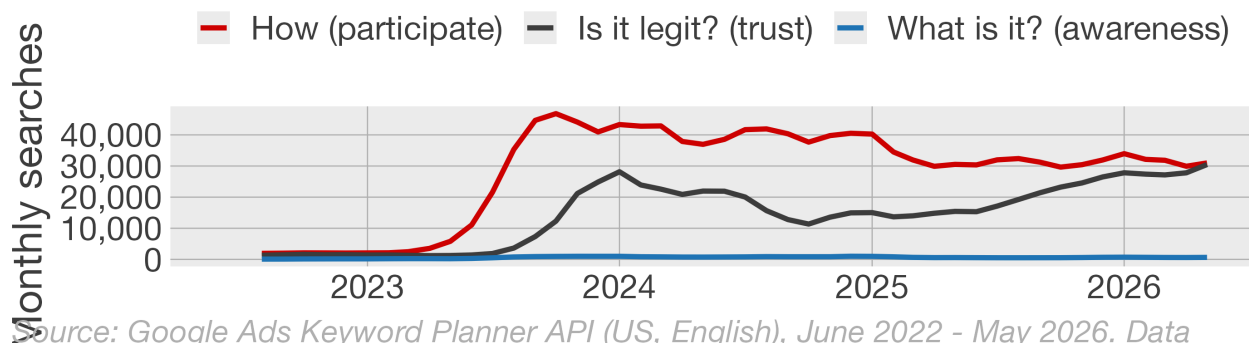
Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
whatnot app	90,500	↑
whatnot com	6,600	↑
whatnot auction	2,900	→
whatnot fees	1,900	↑
whatnot shop	1,900	↑
whatnot seller fees	1,600	↑
whatnot seller	880	→

How the questions mature

There is a natural life-cycle to how people search a new category: first *what is it?*, then *is it safe?*, then *how do I do it?* Bucketing live-shopping question queries by type and tracking them over time (Figure 11) shows the US market moving decisively into the third phase.

From “what is it” to “how do I do it”: the questions mature with the market

Monthly search volume of question queries about live shopping, by type (3-mo avg).



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

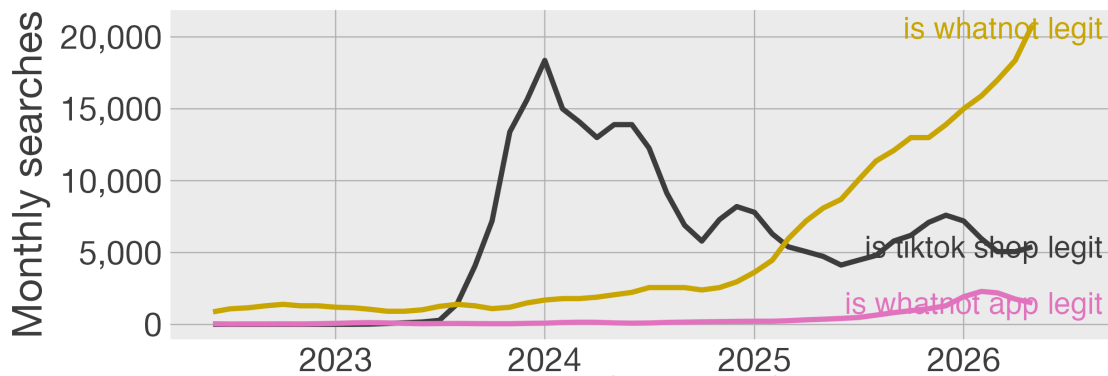
Figure 11: Question queries about live shopping over time, by type. “How” (participation) now dominates “what” (awareness) and “is it legit” (trust).

“How” questions now dominate - averaging nearly 28,000 searches a month versus ~15,000 for trust (“is it legit”) questions, while bare “what is it” awareness queries have dwindled to a few hundred. This is the signature of a maturing market: the centre of gravity has shifted from *understanding* live shopping to *participating* in it - how to sell, how to use the apps, how to get started. The awareness phase is essentially over. The two phases that remain live - participation (“how”) and trust (“is it legit”) - are the two that platforms can most directly influence, and they are the subject of the next two sections.

Trust: “is it legit?”

Trust is the gating question: “is it legit?” searches climb with adoption

US monthly searches for legitimacy queries, 3-month moving average. Inline labels at right.



Source: Google Ads Keyword Planner API (US, English), June 2022 - May 2026. Data retrieved June 2026. Index = normalized U.S. search volume, first month = 100.

Figure 12: Legitimacy queries scale with adoption. TikTok Shop legitimacy fears spiked after its 2023 US launch then eased; “is whatnot legit” has climbed steadily and now leads.

As live shopping goes mainstream, consumers do something very human: they ask whether they can trust it. Figure 12 tracks legitimacy queries:

- “**Is TikTok Shop legit**” spiked dramatically after the 2023 US launch - a wave of skepticism about a new, unfamiliar, algorithm-driven storefront - then eased as the format became familiar.
- “**Is Whatnot legit**” has climbed steadily and now **leads**, which is exactly what you would expect from a platform moving from niche to mainstream: more new buyers means more first-time due-diligence searches.

The qualitative concerns behind these searches are consistent across platforms: counterfeit or low-quality goods, items that never arrive (often small international sellers), and refund friction. The practical implication for platforms is that **trust infrastructure - verified sellers, buyer protection, transparent fees, dispute resolution - is now a growth lever, not a compliance cost**. Trust questions are not a sign of trouble; they are a sign of scale. But the platform that answers them best will convert the most skeptics.

Vertical breakouts

Two complementary views of “what sells live” emerge from the data.

On the search side, collectibles still lead. Within a live-shopping context, **trading cards and “breaks”** have the deepest and fastest-growing vocabulary - dozens of distinct, intent-rich terms that grew ~86% over the window, the single clearest vertical signal. (Two caveats on magnitude. First, the raw bucket total is *not* a

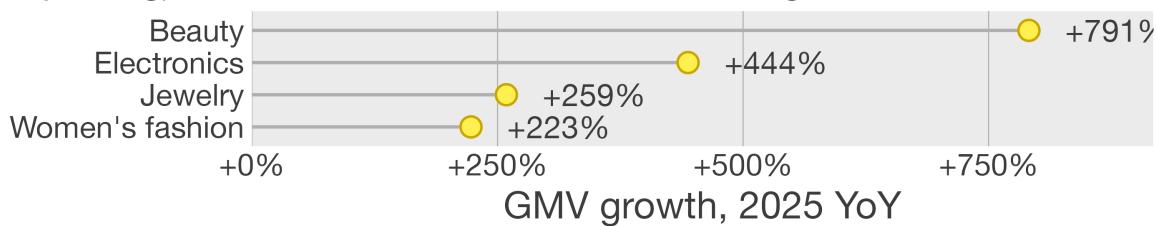
clean cross-vertical ranking: the card vocabulary is captured by ~40 specific keywords while other verticals contribute only a handful, so any direct “X times larger than the next vertical” comparison mostly reflects how finely each category is enumerated, not true relative demand. Second, the card-break terms are small and spiky - several individual keywords showed implausible 20-30x one-month jumps. After rationalizing those bucketing artefacts, the vertical’s growth comes down from a raw ~135% to the ~86% we report.) What is robust is the *depth and momentum* of the vocabulary: this is the cultural engine that built Whatnot, Fanatics Live and eBay Live, and it remains the gateway drug into live shopping.

On the GMV side, the mix is broadening fast. Whatnot’s own 2025 reporting shows its fastest-growing categories by GMV are now well beyond collectibles:

Category	Whatnot GMV growth (2025, YoY)
Beauty	+791%
Electronics	+444%
Jewelry	+259%
Women’s fashion	+223%

Beyond collectibles: where Whatnot’s dollars are growing fastest

Whatnot GMV growth by category, 2025 vs 2024 (company reporting). The mass-retail verticals are scaling hardest.



Source: Whatnot public reporting / trade press, 2025-2026. Search data elsewhere from Google Ads Keyword Planner API.

Figure 13: Whatnot GMV growth by category, 2025 vs 2024 (company reporting). The mass-retail verticals - beauty, electronics, jewelry, fashion - are scaling fastest, well beyond the collectibles roots.

The reconciliation between the two views is the insight: **collectibles are the top of the funnel** (they bring passionate, daily-active users in), while **beauty, fashion, electronics and jewelry are where the dollars are scaling**. A platform that converts a card collector into a beauty or fashion buyer captures both the engagement and the basket.

A closer look at the individual verticals:

- **Trading cards & sports memorabilia.** The original engine. The vocabulary is deep and fragmented (*breaks, rips*, set-specific terms), signalling a committed community rather than a casual audience. This is where Fanatics Live and eBay Live concentrate, and where Whatnot built its habit. Steady rather than explosive in search - because it is already mature within live shopping.
- **Beauty.** The fastest-growing GMV vertical on Whatnot (+791%) and a natural fit for live demonstration (swatches, tutorials, before/after). Notably, beauty also shows up heavily in **QVC/HSN** search (*qvc makeup*,

qvc skincare) - the legacy networks’ historical strength, now being carried into live-social. Beauty is the clearest example of live shopping crossing from hobbyist niche to mass retail.

- **Women’s fashion & apparel.** Whatnot’s fastest-growing *segment*, with individual sellers reportedly crossing \$1M/month via clothing hauls and liquidation streams. Apparel suits the format’s impulse-and-scarcity dynamics (limited sizes, “going once”), and resale/thrift gives it a sustainability angle that resonates with younger buyers.
- **Electronics & gadgets.** +444% GMV on Whatnot and a staple of TikTok Shop’s deal-driven feed. Lower emotional engagement than collectibles, but high basket sizes and strong promotional response.
- **Jewelry & watches.** +259% GMV on Whatnot; eBay Live’s expansion into luxury watches and handbags targets exactly this. High average order values make even modest volumes lucrative.
- **Plants, ceramics & “weird niches.”** The frontier. Palmstreet’s breakout shows that almost any passionate collecting community can support a live marketplace - the model generalizes wherever there is a hobby, a community, and items worth showing in real time.

Live auctions: a parallel format

A distinct but related behaviour runs underneath the headline trend: **live auctions**. Bid-based, time-pressured, collectibles-led selling (cards, sneakers, coins, comics, Funko) shows up in queries like *ebay live auction* and underpins much of Whatnot’s and Fanatics Live’s engagement. Auctions carry a different psychology from fixed-price live shopping - higher intensity, social competition, and a “win” payoff - and they map onto the same collectibles verticals that lead the category. StockX Live’s 2026 entry is explicitly auction-and-drop flavoured. Auctions are worth tracking as a leading indicator: they tend to attract the most engaged users first.

Table 12: Sample of live-auction queries (334 in the universe). Note that some “live auction” terms also refer to offline auctions.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
live auction	40,500	↓
ebay live auction	2,900	↑
live auction sites	2,400	↑
live auction app	720	→
whatnot live auction	390	→
live bidding	260	→

The split mirrors the platform story: the generic, partly-offline “*live auction*” term drifts down, while the **platform-attached** auction terms (*ebay live auction*, *whatnot live auction*) and the app/sites queries rise. Auctions are not fading; they are **moving onto live-commerce platforms**.

The long tail: where tomorrow's trends hide

A recurring theme of this research is that the interesting signal is rarely in the head terms. Roughly **95% of all search queries** (across every topic, not just this one) get fewer than ten searches a month. In an emerging category, that long tail is not noise to be discarded - it is the leading edge, the place where a behaviour is visible before it has a name.

The table below mixes mid-volume and very-low-volume live-shopping terms to make the point. A term like *taobao live shopping* (10/month) is a faint echo of the mature Chinese market; *live thrifting* and *whatnot live auction* are small today but describe behaviours that could be large tomorrow.

Table 13: A walk down the long tail.

Keyword	Avg. monthly searches	4-yr trend
whatnot auction	2,900	→
palmstreet app	1,000	↑
live sports card breaks	320	→
how to start selling on whatnot	260	→
live thrifting	210	→
whatnot live auction	390	→
taobao live shopping	10	→

The practical implication: anyone trying to ride this category - a brand, a platform, a host - should be watching the sub-100-searches-a-month terms, because by the time a query is large, the opportunity to be early is gone.

Where the opportunities are

The search data does not just describe the market; it hints at gaps. A few opportunities that fall out of the patterns above (offered as prompts, not predictions):

- **Multi-platform “go live once” tooling.** Sellers increasingly search across Whatnot, TikTok Shop, eBay Live and others. Tooling that lets a host broadcast to several platforms at once while keeping chat and cart unified addresses a real, visible pain.
- **A “live selling starter kit.”** The surge in *how to sell* / *seller fees* queries reveals a wave of aspiring sellers who lack training and basic gear. Education plus a simple equipment bundle is a natural product.
- **Brand-to-platform (and brand-to-host) matching.** With the platform landscape fragmenting into category-native lanes, brands need help picking the right platform and the right host for their vertical - a curation/matchmaking opportunity.
- **Trust as a product.** Because “is it legit?” scales with adoption, verification, buyer-protection and transparent-fee features are not just compliance - they are a differentiator a platform or third party can build around.

Beyond search: corroborating signals and global context

Search interest is one lens; it is more convincing when other signals point the same way.

Other attention signals agree. Whatnot's rise is mirrored in YouTube search, Reddit activity, and Wikipedia pageviews - all "up and to the right." The same holds for the category broadly: live-shopping subreddits have grown, creator content explaining "how to sell on TikTok Shop / Whatnot" has proliferated, and the trade press now covers the space as a category rather than a curiosity. When independent attention signals move together, the underlying shift is more likely real than an artefact of one data source.

Business metrics agree. The search inflection is matched by hard numbers: Whatnot's GMV roughly doubling to \$6B+, TikTok Shop's US GMV rising to ~\$15B, eBay Live's geographic expansion, StockX's decision to build a live product, and QVC Group's strategic (if financially strained) pivot. Search led; the dollars followed.

Global context: the ceiling is high. In China, live commerce is estimated to account for roughly **60% of e-commerce**; in the US, the figure is around **5%**. Whether or not the US ever approaches Chinese penetration, the gap frames the opportunity: even a partial convergence implies years of structural growth. The US is also taking a recognisably different path - community-and-collectibles-led, and domestically built - rather than copying the Chinese super-app model wholesale.

Risks: what could derail the breakout

The base case is constructive, but a credible report names the ways it could be wrong.

- **Trust erosion at scale.** The biggest risk is the flip side of the biggest opportunity. If counterfeits, non-delivery, and refund friction grow faster than verification and buyer protection, the "is it legit?" question could curdle from healthy curiosity into mainstream distrust - the one thing that reliably kills a nascent consumer behaviour.
- **TikTok execution risk.** The ownership question is resolved, but the new US joint venture still has to run a complex marketplace, keep creators and sellers engaged, and grow the *live* share of GMV (still only ~14%). Missteps at the largest discovery funnel would slow the whole category.
- **Seller economics and churn.** The supply surge is real, but live selling is hard work with thin margins for many. If aspiring sellers churn out faster than they are recruited - or if fee changes sour sentiment (note the rising *seller fees* queries) - the supply engine could stall.
- **Concentration risk.** Whatnot's dominance is a strength and a fragility: a single platform carrying so much of the category's momentum means its stumbles would be the category's stumbles.
- **Macro and attention competition.** Live shopping competes for discretionary spend and, just as critically, for attention. A consumer pullback or a shift in where people spend their screen time would pressure a format that depends on both.

What it means - by stakeholder

The same data reads differently depending on where you sit. A consolidated view:

For platforms and marketplaces

- **Win a community before a category.** Every durable destination started by owning a passionate vertical, then expanded. Generic “live video + cart” has repeatedly failed; community-native formats have repeatedly won.
- **Treat trust as a product, not a policy.** “Is it legit?” scales with adoption; the platform that most visibly solves verification, buyer protection and dispute resolution converts the most skeptics into buyers.

For incumbent retailers and brands

- **Re-platform; don’t wait to be displaced.** QVC/HSN’s migration onto streaming, social and a 24/7 TikTok channel shows incumbents can convert legacy audiences - the rising “official site”/app search proves the audience is willing to move.
- **Match the platform to the vertical.** The landscape is a federation of lanes (cards to Fanatics/eBay, beauty/fashion to TikTok Shop and Whatnot, drops to NTWRK’s successors). There is no single “live shopping channel” to plug into.
- **The mass verticals are the prize.** Beauty, electronics, jewelry and fashion are scaling fastest by GMV - the dollars have moved well beyond the collectibles roots.

For sellers and creators

- **You are early.** The seller ecosystem is forming now. The surge in “how to sell” queries is your competition arriving - but the audience is arriving faster.
- **Mind the economics.** Rising “seller fees” searches signal that take-rates and margins are front of mind. Platform choice is increasingly an economic decision, not just an audience one.

For investors and analysts

- **Watch the live-selling index as the leading dashboard** - it leads consumer interest by roughly two quarters.
- **Distinguish the flash from the floor.** Event spikes (the TikTok ban) mostly revert; the durable signal is the rising baseline.

What search data can - and cannot - tell you

In the spirit of intellectual honesty, it is worth being explicit about the method’s limits.

What it does well. Search is an unbiased, real-time, behavioural signal. Nobody searches to please a pollster. It captures *latent demand* (people considering live shopping before they buy), *supply intent* (people learning to sell before they are onboarded), and *trust friction* (people checking legitimacy before they commit) - often months before any of these show up in GMV. Because it is continuous and granular, it surfaces micro-trends (Palmstreet, “live thrifting”) while they are still tiny.

What it cannot do. Search interest is attention, not transactions: a query is not a sale, and the relationship between the two varies by category. Keyword Planner volumes are *bucketed* (reported in bands), so absolute numbers are best read as orders of magnitude. Brand search and category search can diverge - as Whatnot shows - so any single basket undercounts the platforms that have become verbs. And search cannot explain *why*: it can show that “is whatnot legit” is rising, but not what specifically reassures or alarms a shopper. The right posture is to treat search as a **leading, directional indicator** to be triangulated against GMV, funding, app rankings and qualitative research - which is exactly how this report uses it.

Outlook and implications

The base case for 2026-27 is continued, structurally higher growth. The category cleared three overhangs at once: Meta's exit is fully digested, TikTok's ownership question is resolved, and a category-native champion (Whatnot) has both the GMV trajectory and the capital to keep expanding. Search interest sits on a higher plateau, the supply side is heating up faster than the demand side, and incumbents (QVC/HSN) are re-platforming rather than disappearing.

What to watch:

- **Can supply scale with trust intact?** The gating risk is no longer demand - it is whether platforms can grow sellers and inventory without letting counterfeits, non-delivery and refund friction erode the trust that adoption depends on.
- **Does the vertical mix keep broadening?** If beauty, fashion and electronics keep compounding the way collectibles did, live shopping graduates from a hobbyist niche to a mainstream retail channel.
- **TikTok Shop's live mix.** Livestreams are still a minority of TikTok Shop GMV (~14% in 2025 vs ~10% in 2024); if that share climbs now that the ownership question is settled, it would meaningfully lift the whole category.
- **The challengers' lanes.** Fanatics Live, eBay Live, Palmstreet and the incoming StockX Live suggest the future is a **federation of category-native live marketplaces**, not a single winner-take-all app.

The one-line takeaway: **US live shopping in 2026 is no longer a question of "if" - it is a question of how fast supply and trust can scale to meet demand that has already inflected.**

A watchlist for 2026-27

If this report were a dashboard, these are the dials worth checking each quarter - chosen because each one is an early, decision-relevant signal rather than a lagging headline:

Table 14: A quarterly watchlist of leading signals.

Signal	Why it matters	What would change the story
Live-selling index	Leads consumer interest by ~2 quarters	A sustained roll-over would warn of a slowdown before GMV shows it
TikTok Shop live-GMV share	Live is still only ~14% of its GMV	A rising live share would lift the whole category
StockX Live launch (summer 2026)	A credible, capitalised new entrant	Fast search traction would validate the auction-and-drops model
New-entrant pipeline	Palmstreet showed the lane is open	The next near-zero breakout is the next Palmstreet
“Is it legit?” trajectory	Trust gates mainstream adoption	A sharp acceleration would flag a trust problem at scale
Seller-fee / seller-economics queries	Supply is the constraint	Rising discontent would threaten the supply engine
QVC Group post-restructuring	Test of incumbent re-platforming	Success or failure here generalises to all legacy retail

Taken together, these dials describe a category that has cleared its existential questions and now turns on execution: **scaling supply and trust**. The demand has already inflected; 2026-27 will be decided by how well the industry meets it.

Appendix

Methodology details

- **Source:** Google Ads Keyword Planner API (keyword ideas + historical metrics), US (location 2840), English (language 1000).
- **Window:** June 2022 - May 2026 (48 months), retrieved June 2026. The Keyword Planner returns a rolling 48-month window; the analysis uses only that fresh window and splices in no older data.
- **Seeds -> universe:** ~7,700 curated seeds (covering established and emerging platforms and verticals) expanded to ~257,000 raw ideas, de-duplicated (including metric-identical keyword collisions) to ~79,000 unique keywords with complete 48-month histories.
- **Indices:** the Live Shopping basket matches *live shop*, *livestream shop*, *live commerce*, *live stream shop*, *livestream commerce*; the Live Selling basket matches *live sell*. Monthly volumes are summed across the basket and normalized so the first month = 100. Charts use a right-aligned 3-month moving average.
- **Trend stats:** per-keyword 3-month rolling average and an OLS linear trend (slope, R-squared) on keywords with a meaningful signal (max monthly volume > 20, fewer than 47 zero months).
- **Spike rationalization:** Keyword Planner volumes are reported in coarse buckets, so an individual keyword can jump several buckets for a single month and then fully revert. These isolated one-month spikes are artefacts, not demand, and they distort summed indices and per-vertical totals. Before any index is built, each keyword's monthly series is passed through a despiking filter that caps a month only when it is **both** a sharp local outlier (at least ~4x its larger neighbouring month) **and** large relative to the keyword's own non-zero median (at least ~5x). The cap is set to roughly twice the neighbouring month. Sustained rises and recurring seasonal peaks (whose neighbours are also elevated) and broad market-wide moves (which lift many keywords together) are preserved; only egregious single-keyword, single-month artefacts are tamed. About 5,000 keywords (~8,000 of ~3.8M month-cells) were touched. The most consequential effect was dissolving an apparent January-2025 index spike that was driven almost entirely by one keyword.
- **Exclusions:** known bot-inflated terms are removed; international markets are out of scope. The term *what is a whatnot* is dropped from every index, trend and table because "a whatnot" is also a common piece of furniture (a tiered display stand), making the query too ambiguous to treat as live-shopping intent.
- **Theme tables:** keyword samples in the micro-trend tables are drawn from the cleaned universe by topic pattern and shown with average monthly searches and a "4-yr trend" label derived from the linear-trend slope (up / flat / down). Samples are curated for relevance and are illustrative, not exhaustive; volumes are Keyword Planner buckets.

The data funnel

The universe was built in stages, each one narrowing toward signal:

Table 15: The seed-to-index funnel.

Stage	Count	What it is
Curated seeds	~7,700	Seeds covering established and emerging platforms and verticals
Raw keyword ideas	~257,000	Google's keyword-ideas expansion of those seeds
Unique keywords (cleaned)	~79,000	After de-duplication, including metric-identical collisions
Modelable keywords	~57,000	After dropping near-zero / sparse series
Live-shopping basket	~196	Index constituents matching the live-shopping pattern
Live-selling basket	~107	Index constituents matching the live-selling pattern

The index basket

The live-shopping index is built from queries that explicitly express live-shopping intent. They fall into five broad groups (with representative examples):

- **Definitions & concepts** - *live shopping, livestream shopping, live commerce, what is live shopping.*
- **Social platforms** - *tiktok live shopping, instagram live shopping, youtube live shopping, facebook live shopping.*
- **How-to & tools** - *live shopping app, live shopping platform, live stream shopping platform.*
- **Retailers & marketplaces** - *whatnot live shopping, amazon live shopping, qvc live shopping, hsn live shopping, ebay live shopping.*
- **Software providers** - vendor-named live-shopping tooling (e.g. *bambuser live shopping*).

Standalone brand terms (e.g. “whatnot” on its own) sit *outside* this intent basket by design, which is why brand-level analyses in this report are run separately from the index.

Glossary

- **Live shopping / live commerce** - real-time, video-led selling where a host presents products to a live audience that can buy, bid, and chat in the moment.
- **Live selling** - the seller-side of the same activity; the act of hosting and selling on a live stream.
- **GMV (gross merchandise value)** - the total value of goods sold through a platform; the standard scale metric for marketplaces.
- **Break / card break** - a live event where a host opens sealed trading-card product and distributes cards to buyers who purchased slots; a core collectibles format.
- **Drop** - a scheduled release of limited-quantity items, often with scarcity and hype (streetwear, sneakers, collectibles).
- **Search-interest index** - here, normalized total monthly Google search volume across a curated basket of queries, set to 100 in the first month of the window.
- **Slope (trend)** - the average monthly change in a keyword's smoothed search volume, used to rank growth.

- **Head term / long tail** - high-volume general queries (head) versus the vast number of low-volume specific queries (long tail), where early signals often appear first.

Caveats

Search interest is a proxy for attention, not a direct measure of sales. Absolute Keyword Planner volumes are bucketed and should be read as orders of magnitude. GMV, funding and event figures are drawn from public reporting and company statements (see sources) and are estimates.

Selected sources

- **Whatnot** (GMV, valuation, categories, engagement): Business of Fashion; Digital Commerce 360; Tech-Funding News; Sacra; Fortune; Marketplace Pulse; FashionNetwork; Whatnot 2026 trends.
- **TikTok Shop** (US GMV, sellers, live mix): Momentum Works / The Low Down; FastMoss; Statista; Marketing LTB.
- **TikTok ownership deal** (Jan 2026 USDS joint venture): TechCrunch; Marketplace; Retail TouchPoints.
- **QVC Group** (rebrand, TikTok channel, Chapter 11): QVC Group SEC 8-K filings (CIK 1355096).
- **Challengers** (StockX Live, Fanatics Live, eBay Live, Popshop/CommentSold): PR Newswire; WWD; CNBC; Value Added Resource; Retail Dive.
- **Market size / adoption / trust**: GetStream; Grand View Research; Statista; eMarketer; consumer-trust coverage (Surfshark, TrustDALE, Avast, University of Kentucky ITS).

Reproducible code and data pipeline on GitHub: github.com/papageorgiou/livestream-shopping-research (the 2026 edition lives in `pipeline-2026/` and `report-2026/`).